

village of Le Roncole, near Busseto, in northern Italy. He picked up the basics of music from the organist at the village church. When he was sent away to school in Busseto at the age of 10, his musical talent attracted the attention of a wealthy local businessman and amateur musician, Antonio Barezzi, who became Verdi's patron.

The Barezzi family

When Verdi was 18, Barezzi sent him to Milan to study music at the Conservatory, but his untutored skills were inadequate to gain admission. Instead he took private lessons, funded by Barezzi, while learning about musical drama by attending performances at Milan's La Scala opera house. After two years in Milan, Verdi returned to Busseto to take up the post of director of municipal music and marry his patron's daughter, Margherita Barezzi. The couple had two children, both of whom died in infancy and were followed to the grave by their 26-year-old mother in 1840.

Through this time of personal tragedy, Verdi was founding his career as a composer. Using the contacts he had made in Milan, in 1839 he succeeded in having his first opera, *Oberto*, staged at La Scala, where it was well received. Accordingly he was commissioned to write three more operas; the first, *Un giorno di regno*, was a complete flop, pulled after a single performance. Verdi vowed never to compose another opera, but the La Scala management pressed upon him a Bible-based libretto by Temistocle Solera, relating the conquest and exile of the Jews by the king of Babylon. First staged in 1842, *Nabucco* was a sensational hit, running for 57 performances. The high point of